A Performance Characterization of CPU–GPU Edge Detection using OpenMP and CUDA

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Abstract—Accelerating an edge-detection kernel does not necessarily reduce host-visible image-processing latency. We characterize sequential C++, OpenMP, CUDA, shared-memory Sobel, and row-partitioned CPU–GPU Sobel on an Intel Core i7-13700HX and NVIDIA RTX 4060 Laptop GPU. A custom Canny variant provides a contrasting CPU workload with global hysteresis. Three procedural grayscale families at four resolutions yield 3780 retained observations across 252 configurations, with output validation outside every timed interval. At 4096 × 4096, pooled median Sobel latency is 37.318 ms sequentially, 5.996 ms with eight OpenMP threads, and 9.839 ms for baseline CUDA including staging and transfers. Shared-memory tiling increases measured kernel time in the tested configurations. Hybrid results depend on resolution and measurement context; a simple fitted partition model has 6.13% mean absolute percentage error on the held-out largest resolution. These are bounded, single-session characterization results, not a novel scheduler or a claim of general GPU superiority. The accompanying artifact preserves individual timings, source hashes, analysis scripts, and explicit algorithm and timing contracts.

Index Terms—edge detection, Sobel, Canny, OpenMP, CUDA, heterogeneous computing, performance characterization

I. INTRODUCTION

Edge detection shows a useful contract between regular localized computation and multi-stage processing with global connectivity. A Sobel output takes into account a small neighborhood which makes spatial partitioning simple. Canny adds smoothing by using nonmaximum suppression and hysteresis, so distributing individual stages or image regions introduces different correctness measures. Canny originally emphasizes more on detection and localization rather than parallel implementation [1].

For a discrete GPU, a short convolution can be completed quickly while host staging, transfers and synchronization dominate application-visible latency. The CUDA based programming model shows parallelism and memory hierarchy [2]; it however does not guarantee that offloading every image will be profitable. Multicore CPU execution is a essential addition for comparison as relying on just sequential baseline is not enough. Benchmark diversity and communication accounting are main concerns in heterogeneous evaluation. [3]

We question how image size, CPU thread count, CUDA launch configuration and CPU row fraction change latency under identical Sobel contract. The study uses a reproducible implementation and measurement artifact, a comparison between kernel and pipeline timing, and a held-out diagnostic model of candidate row allocations. It does not claim a new edge detector or a new CPU-GPU dividing principle or an optimized search model. Prior work already addresses adaptive mapping and cooperative image processing. Our scope is a controlled course-project characterization limited to one commodity laptop.

II. RELATED WORK

Luo and Duraiswami implement a complete CUDA Canny, including hysteresis and compare it against CPU software [4]. Emrani et al. compute several detectors and replace a breadth-first procedure with a parallel approach [5]. Mochurad studies CUDA Canny with image size and noise related analysis [6]. Song et al. compare serial, OpenMP, CUDA and OpenCL Canny and investigate access and launch organization [7] These works rule out a novelty claim that is simply based on GPU edge detection or comparing programming models. Canny variants also show difference in smoothing, thresholding and connectivity; published speedups are not directly transferable to what we are implementing.

Chang et al. optimize a four direction 5 x 5 Sobel operator using warp primitives and prefetching on two GPU platforms [8]. That operator differs from a bi-directional 3x3 L1 magnitude workload that we optimize. Stencil auto-tuning [9] and Halide's separation of image algorithms from schedules [10] establish that localised transformation and execution schedules are widely discussed optimization topics. Shared memory is therefore not an asserted contribution , but an experimentally evaluated candidate.

Qilin uses an adaptive CPU-GPU mapping [11]. StarPU provides a heterogenous task scheduling and data management [12]; SKMD partitions OpenCL kernels while keeping in mind for transfers and device performance [13]. Cooperative CUDA execution [14], Fluidic Kernels [15], and performance aware image analysis scheduling [16] further establish this field. A survey provides a comprehensive comparison of CPU-GPU techniques [17]. Particularly close recent work by Huang et al. models stage level CPU/GPU Canny configuration with explicit transfer costs and latency objectives [18]. Our small row split model is substantially narrower and is in no manner a replacement for these systems.

Roofline relates performance with computation and movement of data [19]. but these measurements do not include the counters that are required for a quantitative roofline diagnosis. Performance evaluation work warns us about setup bias [20] and the need for characterize variability [21]. We therefore preserve all our observations and report detailed summaries without statistical significance claims. The artifact

contains a complete 21-publication review matrix, with full text and abstract only evidence distinguished.

III. PROBLEM FORMULATION AND RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Let an image contain N = WH grayscale samples and let f ∈ [0, 1] denote the fraction of rows assigned to the CPU. Our main metric is uniform workspace wall latency. This assumes that the host input and output already exist, and the reusable device and pinned buffers have already been allocated. The measured time includes staging, transfers, computation, synchronization, and output merging. File I/O, image generation, context creation, workspace allocation and correctness checks are not considered. Therefore, this is not the total application startup time.

We investigate majorly three questions. RQ1: how is OpenMP scaling different from local Sobel and multi stage Canny? RQ2 examines whether shared memory Sobel kernels improve kernel time or latency? RQ3 looks at when row partitioning performs better than device only execution, and how well can a small model extrapolate to a larger image? We expect over head to have a better effect on small inputs, providing limited benefit for a small stencil, and that an allocation based on full image rates does not necessarily reduce pipeline latency. These hypotheses are tested only for the configuration, used in the study. For endpoint throughputs PC = N/TC and PG = N/TG, an initial estimate is

This estimate takes the assumption that work can be divided according to ideal processing rates. However, fixed overheads, halo rows and resource contention can have an affect on the results. We compare the nearest tested fraction with the best fraction observed in the whole experiment, while not treating either as a global optimum.

IV. SYSTEM DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION

A. Algorithm contracts

All inputs are 8-bit grayscale images. Sobel uses the conventional horizontal mask [−1, 0, 1; −2, 0, 2; −1, 0, 1] and its transpose, with signed integer accumulation and unsigned 16-bit output |Gx| + |Gy|.

The outermost output border is set to zero, with no clipping, normalization or thresholding. Integer arithmetic allows exact comparison between CPU and GPU results.

The Canny implementation uses a 5×5 smoothing filter formed from the binomial coefficients ([1,4,6,4,1]), normalized by 256. Boundary samples are replicated during smoothing. Sobel gradients are then calculated using floating-point arithmetic to obtain magnitudes and directions. Non-maximum suppression groups directions into four bins, retains ties and sets the outer border to zero. Absolute thresholds of 40 and 100 are used. Finally, a global serial queue follows eight-connected weak pixels starting from strong pixels. No stage uses OpenCV. This implementation follows a specific Canny variant and does not aim to reproduce every library implementation or the original multiscale detector.

B. CPU and CUDA execution

OpenMP parallelizes independent rows using static scheduling and configurable thread counts [22]. Dynamic adjustment is disabled. In Canny, smoothing, gradient calculation and suppression are parallelized, while global hysteresis remains serial. Canny latency also includes temporary allocations, unlike Sobel, which uses reusable arrays. Therefore, latency differences between the two algorithms are descriptive rather than a direct comparison of equivalent workloads.

The baseline CUDA implementation assigns one thread to each output pixel. The tiled version loads a block and its one-pixel halo into shared memory. All threads reach the synchronization barrier before out-of-range threads return. The tested block configurations are 16 × 16, 32 × 8 and 32 × 16. CUDA calls and launches are checked, and results are read after stream synchronization. Timing distinguishes device execution intervals from host-visible wall time, following CUDA guidance [23].

Hybrid Sobel assigns the upper ⌊f H⌋ rows to eight OpenMP threads and the lower rows to CUDA. One preceding halo row is transferred when required, and CPU and GPU outputs occupy separate regions. Pinned host memory supports asynchronous transfer submission through a non-blocking stream. CPU processing starts after the GPU operations are queued, after which the host waits for completion and copies the GPU output into the final array. Fractions 0 and 1 use the same hybrid wrapper.

Asynchronous submission alone is not proof of overlap. We additionally record the conservative interval bound

Both intervals fall within the overall wall-clock interval. A positive value supports temporal overlap between the CPU region and GPU kernel, but does not prove continuous CPU activity. A zero value is inconclusive because transfers and staging also contribute to wall time. No profiler timeline was collected.

V. EXPERIMENTAL METHODOLOGY

A. Platform and inputs

Experiments ran on Windows 11 Home Single Language, build 26200, with an Intel Core i7-13700HX (16 cores, 24 logical processors), 16,886,128,640 bytes of RAM and an NVIDIA RTX 4060 Laptop GPU with 8188 MiB of memory and compute capability 8.9. The NVIDIA driver was 576.02. The code was compiled using CUDA 12.9.41, MSVC 14.44 and C++17, with host optimization and OpenMP enabled. The target was sm_89, and fast-math was disabled. The GPU also handles the Windows desktop under WDDM.

Three synthetic image families were generated at widths of 512, 1024, 2048 and 4096: fixed-seed xorshift noise, a checker pattern with 17 × 23 cells, and a two-dimensional ramp with a

wrap discontinuity. These patterns provide controlled texture differences but do not represent natural-image populations. Repeating the same family at different sizes is not treated as independent scene evidence. Additional flat, step and irregular-sized images were used for correctness testing.

B. Validation and sampling

The C++ suite passed 984 equivalence checks and three analytical checks. Testing covered dimensions as small as 1 × 1, non-multiples of CUDA block dimensions, six CPU settings, three GPU block shapes and five partition fractions. Sobel was checked against an independent nested-mask implementation. Serial and OpenMP Canny results were compared for consistency, with additional small-input oracle tests. These checks do not prove correctness for every possible connectivity case. Every warm-up and retained benchmark output was also compared with its sequential reference.

Each of the 252 configurations ran in a separate process, with three untimed warm-ups followed by 15 timed observations. Configuration order was shuffled once using seed 3129. OpenMP thread counts were 1, 2, 4, 8 and 16; the sequential path used an inactive parallel region. Dynamic teams were disabled, and passive waiting was requested through the environment. CPU affinity and clock frequencies were not fixed, and runtime settings were not assumed to override all Microsoft runtime behaviour.

CUDA events measured H2D transfers, kernel execution and D2H transfers, while steady_clock measured the complete processing interval. The raw CSV stores timings, configuration details, image family, repetition, correctness, run identifier and warm-up count. A manifest records executable and source hashes along with hardware information. No samples were removed, and no configuration failed.

Results are reported using medians and interquartile ranges (IQRs). Pooled configuration plots contain 45 observations, with 15 from each image family, so their spread reflects both content differences and timing variation. Speedup plots divide each family's sequential median by the corresponding implementation median before summarizing the three ratios. These values may differ from ratios calculated using pooled medians. No confidence intervals or significance claims are made because consecutive observations from one session are not independent replicated experiments.

C. Held-out model

For hybrid-path configuration medians, we fit

where $N_M = N/10^6$. Least squares uses only widths 512, 1024 and 2048 (45 family–fraction medians). All 15 medians at width 4096 are withheld. Predictions are clipped to nonnegative values. This four-coefficient descriptive model approximates a piecewise-linear allocation curve; its coefficients do not separately identify transfer or synchronization costs. MAPE is computed on the held-out configuration medians, not on training observations.

VI. RESULTS

A. Latency and CPU scaling

Table I reports pooled Sobel medians. At the largest size, eight-thread OpenMP is faster than baseline CUDA in this session. Figure 1 shows the trend with quartile bars; the artifact supplies per-family summaries and speedup plots. GPU kernel speed does not translate directly into lower host-visible latency.

Fig. 1. Sobel pipeline latency. Error bars show pooled Q1–Q3, not confidence intervals. All staging and transfers are included.

At 4096 × 4096, pooled Canny medians are 1083.075 ms sequentially and 203.268 ms with 16 threads. Scaling is not monotonic across the measured thread settings. The global serial queue, allocation behavior, image content and operating-system scheduling are plausible contributors, but this experiment does not isolate their causal effects. Figure 2 uses per-family speedups to avoid equating a ratio of pooled timings with a pooled speedup.

Fig. 2. Median of three per-family speedups at 4096 × 4096. The baseline is the same family's sequential implementation.

B. Tiling and data movement

For baseline CUDA at the largest size, median event intervals are 1.334 ms H2D, 0.531 ms kernel and 2.746 ms D2H. The wall median is 9.839 ms. Differences include host staging, merging and runtime overhead; sums of separate medians need not equal the median of their sum. The tiled 16 × 16 kernel takes 0.767 ms, compared with 0.531 ms for the global-memory kernel. Every tested tiled shape has a higher pooled kernel median than baseline at every measured resolution (Fig. 3).

Some tiled pipeline medians are nevertheless slightly lower. Since their kernel work is slower and separately randomized runs have visible spread, these differences do not demonstrate a beneficial tiling optimization. Cache reuse in the baseline and tile-loading/barrier overhead are possible explanations for kernel behavior, but counters were not collected to establish a bottleneck.

Fig. 3. Device event intervals for global and tiled Sobel. Quartile bars summarize all three families. Tiling is a candidate whose measured kernel performance is unfavorable here.

C. Partitions and prediction

Within the hybrid wrapper, pooled best tested CPU fractions are 1.0, 0.75, 1.0 and 0.5 as width increases. At width 4096, the half-CPU split has a 6.528 ms median, versus 9.119 ms at the GPU endpoint and 6.819 ms at the CPU endpoint. How-ever, independently measured eight-thread OpenMP is 5.996 ms. The small within-wrapper gain over its CPU endpoint therefore does not establish superiority over a well-performing CPU-only execution (Fig. 4). Endpoint differences across separate processes expose sensitivity to execution context.

The initial throughput estimate does not always select the best tested fraction. Across the recorded family–size combinations, nearest-grid selection has regret from 0 to 89.35% relative to the lowest observed candidate median. This is a retrospective diagnostic, subject to selection bias and measurement noise, not out-of-sample policy performance.

Fig. 4. Pooled hybrid-wrapper medians across CPU fractions. Endpoint paths and separately timed standalone implementations must be distinguished.

5 hybrid observations have an overlap lower bound greater than 0.01 ms; the largest bound is 0.0556 ms. This supports limited interval overlap in those observations. It does not establish overlap for every configuration or explain latency improvements causally. A synchronized profiler trace would strengthen this validation.

The fitted model yields 6.13% held-out MAPE on the 15 largest-resolution medians. Figure 5 shows individual predictions. The held-out set uses the same three synthetic families and hardware, so this result demonstrates size extrapolation within the study only. It does not establish a portable allocation model or justify selecting arbitrary unmeasured fractions.

Fig. 5. Largest-resolution medians were excluded from fitting. Dashed line denotes exact prediction; color identifies CPU fraction.

VII. DISCUSSION

The primary finding is a difference between where arithmetic runs quickly and where an entire host-to-host image operation runs quickly. For a small regular stencil, device computation is only part of the pipeline. Keeping intermediate data resident on the GPU could change this balance, but it would answer a different question and is not measured here. Adding shared-memory traffic and synchronization can cost more than the reuse it enables. The observed result should inform a future optimization choice, not be hidden by emphasizing a favorable isolated wall-time sample. Similarly, collaborative CPU–GPU execution should be compared against both endpoints under repeated controlled conditions. Merely demonstrating correctness and asynchronous submission is insufficient to claim a practical gain.

The model is useful as a compact description of this dataset, while the rate-estimate regret demonstrates the limits of idealized divisible-work assumptions. The extensive scheduling literature provides stronger general techniques; our study instead makes the timing scope and the limits of a small empirical model inspectable.

VIII. THREATS TO VALIDITY AND LIMITATIONS

This is one laptop and one session. The desktop GPU is shared, CPU placement is uncontrolled, and background activity, thermal state and power policy can affect measurements. Fifteen within-process repetitions characterize local variability without establishing cross-day reproducibility. Table II reports the largest-resolution spread so that small differences are not mistaken for robust improvements.

Only synthetic images are measured. Natural-image generalization, different machines, energy, GPU-resident pipelines, cold-start latency and production-library baselines remain untested. CPU SIMD tuning is not explicitly optimized. OpenMP Canny retains a serial queue and includes intermediate allocation costs; CUDA and hybrid Canny are not implemented. Exact comparison validates the specified algorithms, not perceptual edge quality or agreement with every library. Tests cannot prove absence of all memory errors, and Compute Sanitizer was not run.

The model uses a small, structured dataset and configuration medians. MAPE alone does not validate an allocation decision, and no statistically significant or universally optimal partition is claimed. The review verifies source existence and records reading depth, but is not an exhaustive systematic review. Author information and human validation remain required before submission.

IX. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

Under the specified host-to-host timing contract, OpenMP with eight threads outperforms baseline CUDA Sobel at the largest tested size, despite a short CUDA kernel interval. Shared-memory tiling worsens kernel time in all tested configurations. Hybrid allocation depends on image size and execution context; the evidence does not support a general advantage over CPU-only execution. A small model extrapolates to the held-out largest size with 6.13% MAPE, within a deliberately narrow scope.

Next steps are independent measurement sessions, controlled power and affinity, natural images with documented licenses, profiler-confirmed overlap, allocation-inclusive latency, and GPU Canny with validated global connectivity. These extensions are required before broader performance or scheduling claims.

AI ASSISTANCE DISCLOSURE

OpenAI Codex assisted with implementation, experiment orchestration, analysis scripts and manuscript drafting. Measurements were produced by executed programs, not gener-ated timing values. This draft still requires human review of the code, evidence, authorship, and venue-specific disclosure requirements; no submission or acceptance is represented.

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